दिल्ली प्रौद्योगिकी विश्वविद्यालय
DELHI TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
(Formerly Delhi College of Engineering)

To Whom It May Concern,

I am pleased to recommend Mehak Dhawan, a Grade 12 student at Jumeirah College, Dubai, whom I have mentored since October 2025. I have been a full-time Professor of Economics at Delhi Technological University for over 25 years, during which I have taught and mentored students across different stages of their academic development. Mehak and I began working remotely in October 2025, before she travelled to India in June–July 2026 to continue her research with me in person. This sustained engagement gave me the opportunity to observe her intellectual development closely.

Mehak first approached me with an interest in financial inclusion, technology, and women's economic participation in India. She had recently completed a digital-literacy bootcamp for 25 women, focused on practical digital and financial skills, but the experience had left her with a larger question: why does expanding access to digital and financial infrastructure not necessarily translate into meaningful economic participation? Her instinct was to move from observation to evidence, and this became the starting point of our academic engagement.

I introduced Mehak to empirical techniques including stationarity, cointegration, ARDL modelling, Granger causality, and model-diagnostic tests, while encouraging her to understand the reasoning behind each method rather than apply it mechanically. As her quantitative foundation developed, she refined her inquiry into a more precise question: if millions of Indian women have access to formal bank accounts, why does this access not necessarily translate into their independent use of financial services?

Mehak developed this question into an empirical study of the gender gap in financial inclusion across India. Using data from the Reserve Bank of India, TRAI, and the Ministry of Finance, she constructed a regression model covering 22 states and Union Territories, examining the relationship between digital infrastructure, economic conditions, individual capability, and women's financial inclusion. She framed testable hypotheses, evaluated them systematically, and stress-tested her model through diagnostic checks and multiple iterations using human-development data.

She complemented this analysis with primary fieldwork, personally interviewing 15 women who had participated in digital-literacy programmes. Her quantitative analysis indicated a positive relationship between internet penetration and women's financial inclusion, while per-capita GSDP displayed a negative association in her model. The interviews added an important dimension: access to a financial resource does not necessarily provide the knowledge or confidence required to use it independently. Mehak consequently developed a more nuanced argument around the distinction between financial access and financial agency.

Her research culminated in the publication of her paper in the International Journal of Scientific Research and Review. She subsequently presented the work at the Law Mantra × Maharashtra National Law University conference and the Global Confluence Review conference, where she was recognised as the runner-up presenter.

What pleased me further was that Mehak carried the research back into practice. The findings informed the subsequent development of DigiSakhi, the vernacular digital-literacy initiative she launched to equip women with practical digital, financial, and entrepreneurial skills. I found this progression particularly

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meaningful: an experience with 25 women prompted an economic question; that question developed into rigorous empirical research; and the resulting evidence, in turn, informed a larger intervention.

Over the course of our work, Mehak became increasingly self-directed. She was receptive to feedback without relying on it mechanically, often returning with sharper questions, revised approaches, and ideas for where the inquiry could go next. Having taught and mentored students for more than two decades, I have come to value this transition from receiving instruction to directing one's own inquiry. Mehak made that transition remarkably naturally.

I recommend Mehak Dhawan with full confidence. She combines quantitative ability with intellectual curiosity and a genuine interest in understanding economic questions through evidence. I am confident that she will bring the same rigor, independence, and depth of inquiry to a demanding undergraduate environment.

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